

The Cartographer's Complaint

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There is a particular kind of failure that only becomes visible once the thing has succeeded completely. The map is the clearest case. For most of its history the map was not a description of where things are. It was an argument about what mattered, drawn by someone who had been there, for someone who had not, and everybody involved understood this.

Then it got accurate, and the argument disappeared into the paper.

What the old maps were doing

Open any portolan chart from the fourteenth century and the first thing you notice is that the coastline is extraordinarily good and the interior is nonsense. This was not incompetence. The chart was made for a pilot. A pilot needs harbours, headlands, and the bearing between them. What sits forty miles inland is not merely unknown — it is *irrelevant*, and putting it in would have made the useful part harder to read.

The medieval mappa mundi does the opposite and is equally deliberate. Jerusalem in the centre, Eden at the top, distances hopeless. Nobody navigated with one. They were arguments about the shape of history, drawn in the vocabulary of geography because that was the vocabulary available.

A map that showed everything at full size would be the size of the thing it described, and would tell you nothing at all.

The point is that both charts are honest. Each announces its priorities in its distortions. You can read what the maker cared about directly off the surface, because what they cared about is drawn large and what they did not is drawn small or not at all.

The survey changes the terms

The trigonometric surveys of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries did something genuinely new. They produced maps whose distortions were no longer *expressive*. The projection still lies — every projection lies, a sphere does not go flat — but it lies systematically, according to a rule stated elsewhere, in a document you are not reading.

This is a real gain. It is also a loss, and the loss went unremarked for about two hundred years:

- A survey map does not tell you what it is for.
- It does not tell you who made it, or what they wanted.
- Its authority comes from its method, which is invisible on the page.
- Because it looks like everything, it is trusted about everything.

The old map argued with you. The new map simply asserts, and its assertions are mostly correct, which is precisely what makes the occasional false one so hard to catch.

The complaint proper

Here is the thing a cartographer will tell you after the second drink. Accuracy did not eliminate the choices. It hid them.

Somebody still decides what counts as a road. Somebody decides the minimum population at which a settlement earns a name, and whether the name is the one used by the people living there or the one used by the administration that counted them. Somebody decides that this is a river and that is a drain, that this is a forest and that is timber. None of it is arbitrary and all of it is chosen, and the modern map's great achievement is that you cannot see any of the choosing.

a road is a road when someone decides it is worth the ink

The satellite image completes the process. It appears to involve no choices at all — it is simply what is *there*. Except that it is not: it is a composite, colour-corrected, cloud-removed, seam-blended, sharpened, and taken on different days in different seasons and stitched into a single false noon that never happened anywhere.

Why this is not merely nostalgia

I am not arguing for the mappa mundi. I have used one and I would not want to cross a road with it.

The argument is narrower. When a representation becomes good enough, we stop reading it as a representation. We read it as the thing. And at exactly that moment the representation acquires its greatest power to mislead, because the scepticism that a visibly partial account invites has been switched off by competence.

This is not a problem about maps. Maps are simply the case where it happened first and most completely, which makes them the easiest place to see the shape of it.

The old cartographers signed their work in the distortions. You could tell what a man loved by what he drew too big. It is a strange kind of honesty, available only to people who have not yet learned to be accurate, and it is not coming back.

What can come back is the habit of asking the question the old maps answered without being asked: *who made this, and what did they want me to do with it?* The map will not tell you. It has become far too good for that.

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